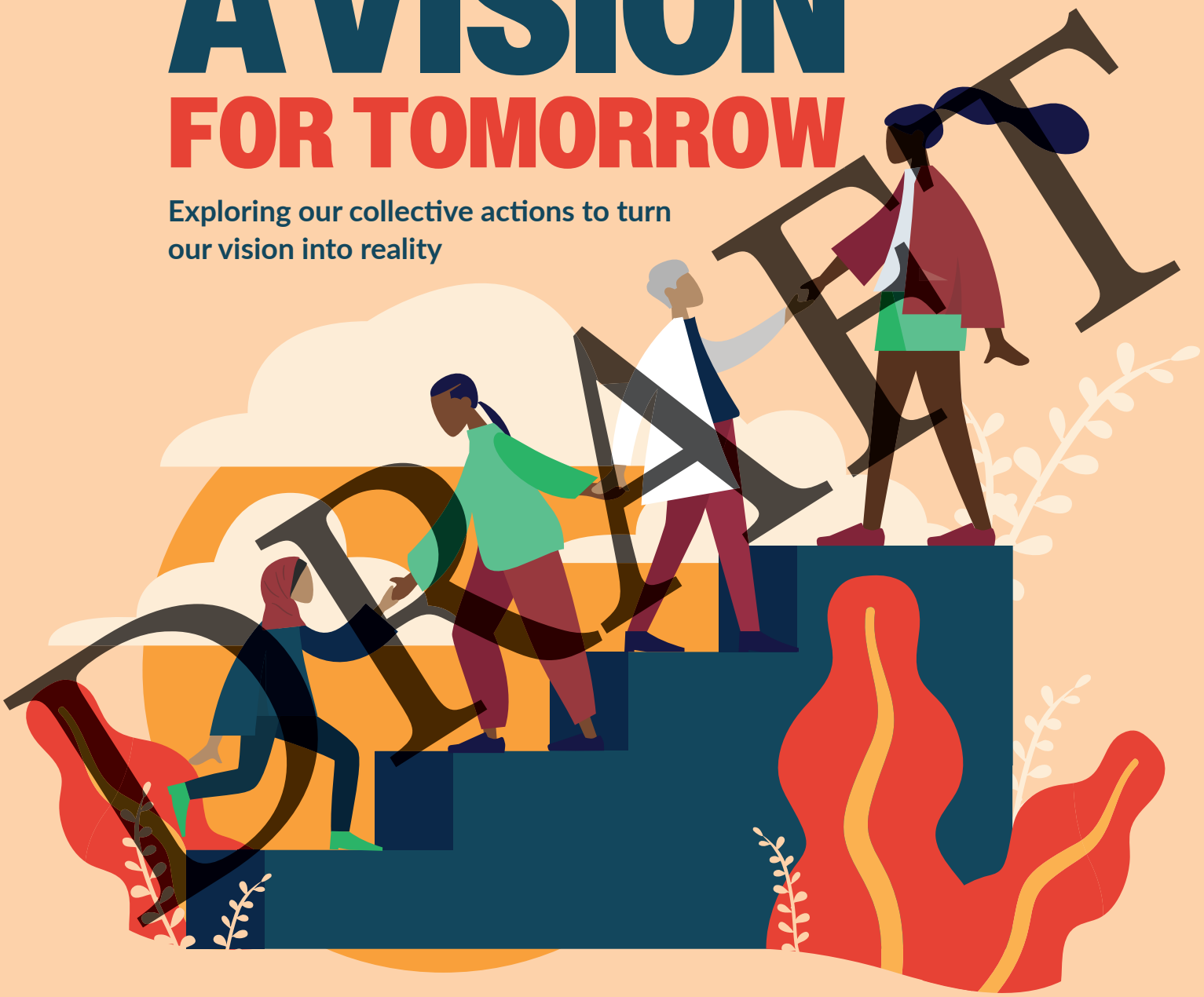
A VISION FOR TOMORROW

Exploring our collective actions to turn our vision into reality



Annual Report 2025-2026

Northern Ontario Research, Development, Ideas and Knowledge

NORDIK INSTITUTE

About NORDIK Institute

NORDIK Institute is a community-based research organization affiliated with Algoma University (AU). Incorporated in 2006, NORDIK grew out of AU's Community Economic and Social Development program due to the demand for localized data, research and place based solutions and serves as a mechanism for university-community partnerships. We undertake diverse initiatives with foci on northern, Indigenous, rural and smaller urban communities. Our mission is to promote more vibrant, caring and sustainable communities through research, dialogue, analysis and reflection dedicated to the practice of holistic community development. NORDIK's approach to community development and research emphasizes the interconnectedness and mutual importance of four pillars of resilience that support healthy, vibrant and fulfilling places: cultural vitality, social equity, environmental sustainability and economic diversity and growth.

VISION

Northern Ontario is a sustainable, inclusive, and self-sufficient region at the forefront of reconciliation and community development.

GOALS AND OBJECTIVES

1

Advance Partnerships for Indigenous Research Sovereignty

2

Foster Local & Regional Evidence-Based Dialogues on Issues Critical to Northern and Indigenous Communities

3

Cultivate Northern Research Talent with a Supportive, Inclusive Team-Based Atmosphere

4

Connect Students, Researchers and Community in Projects that Contribute to Social, Economic & Environmental Sustainability & Justice for Northern and Indigenous Communities

THEME: A VISION FOR TOMORROW

A Vision for Tomorrow reflects NORDIK Institute's commitment to building on 20 years of community-based research, collaboration, and impact while looking ahead to new possibilities. The theme celebrates the relationships, knowledge, and accomplishments that have shaped our journey and invites us to imagine what comes next. As communities face evolving opportunities and challenges, A Vision for Tomorrow emphasizes continued learning, innovation, partnership, and community-driven action to create meaningful and lasting change.



Team Leadership

BOARD OF DIRECTORS

Dave Marasco (Chair)
Steven McCoy (Vice-Chair)
Dr. Derek Rice (Treasurer)
Corina Artuso
Martin Bayer
Krista Bissiallon
Dr. Brett Goodwin
Stevie Luzzi

Delegated position: Amy Boyer (Secretary)

MANAGEMENT TEAM

Dr. Tamanna Rimi (Director of Research)
Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone (Director of Operations)
Dr. Jude Ortiz (Research Coordinator)
Amy Boyer (Manager of Communications)

Graphic Design by Carmen Misasi Design

Messages From NORDIK Institute's Directors

DIRECTOR OF RESEARCH



Dr. Tamanna Rimi

As NORDIK Institute celebrates its 20th anniversary, this milestone provides an opportunity to reflect on how far we have come while also imagining where we want to go next. For two decades, NORDIK has created a space where communities, researchers, students, and organizations work together to better understand community priorities, co-create knowledge, and develop solutions that contribute to stronger and more resilient communities. This remains at the heart of who we are.

This year's theme, **A Vision for Tomorrow**, reflects both continuity and change. During 2025–2026, NORDIK was engaged in **22 projects and more than 40 community collaborations**, addressing issues ranging from Indigenous research sovereignty and community development to health, workforce development, arts and culture, environmental sustainability, data, and emerging technologies. Behind these numbers are relationships—with communities, Research Associates, students, partners, and funders—that make this work possible.

As we look toward the next 20 years, the ways we conduct and mobilize research will continue to evolve. **Artificial intelligence, data analytics, digital platforms, visualization tools, and other emerging technologies offer new possibilities for understanding complex challenges, making knowledge more accessible, and supporting better community decision-making.** We are already seeing this evolution through initiatives that bring together community-based research, data, digital tools, and emerging technologies. But technology should be a **tool, not the driver of our work**. Our challenge is to thoughtfully and responsibly use these new capabilities to better serve communities while maintaining the principles that have guided NORDIK for the past 20 years: community voices, meaningful relationships, Indigenous research sovereignty, collaboration, and locally relevant knowledge.

Our vision for tomorrow, therefore, is not about changing NORDIK's core—it is about **building on that core with new tools, new knowledge, and new partnerships**. We must continue finding better ways to make research visible, accessible, useful, and capable of creating meaningful impact.

As we enter our next chapter, I am deeply grateful to our staff, Research Associates, students, Board members, funders, our community partners, and Algoma University. **The relationships and trust built over the past 20 years are our foundation; how we build upon them will shape NORDIK's next 20.**

DIRECTOR OF OPERATIONS



Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone

In the spirit of this year's theme, we celebrate the long-standing partnerships that enable real community impacts, while looking ahead at a rapidly changing world. After three years of explosive growth at NORDIK Institute, we have made the decision to postpone the business transformation we announced in our last Annual Report, and implement a slowed-growth plan to mitigate many expected and emerging challenges in our 20th anniversary year. We are grateful for our many community partners, who are at the centre of our developing strategy as we reposition the organization to ensure its continued success.

In the 2025-2026 fiscal year, we saw major changes to global trade and economies, the start of geopolitical realignments, increasing conflicts, sweeping technological advancement & adoption, and higher rates of environmental change. All of these shifts have implications on how we conceive A Vision for Tomorrow: more competitive funding; changing data security expectations; emerging national strategies for AI adoption, sovereignty and control; difficulty procuring goods & services, including accessing experts and retaining talent; reduced community engagement due to increasing costs of basic needs (e.g., food, energy); increasingly crippling environmental conditions (e.g., fires, flooding, drought, winter conditions); and the rapidly evolving capacities and roles of Ontario universities.

NORDIK Institute is already seeing the effects of some of these changes on our operations, and we look forward to leveraging proven approaches together with community-focused technologies as we collaborate to develop a strategy for success in the coming years. Our technological capabilities include aerial photography and surveys, digital twins, ground-penetrating radar, digital tool development (e.g., software, databases & dashboards), new uses for machine learning, deploying artificial intelligence, and related analytical services - all focused on building community capacities and strengthening community data sovereignty. We invite collaborators, old and new, to be a part of our new chapter!

A FAREWELL TO AMY BOYER

After four years as a member of NORDIK Institute's Management Team, and many years prior engaging with our teams and community initiatives, we said a fond farewell to our Manager of Communications, Amy Boyer. Throughout her time with NORDIK Institute, Amy played an important role in strengthening our communications and helping us share the stories of our research, projects, partnerships, and community impact. Her thoughtful approach helped make NORDIK's work more visible and accessible to the communities and partners we serve.

Amy brought more than her communications expertise to NORDIK. She brought warmth, positive energy, and a smiling face that made people feel welcome. Amy was always a trusted confidant and a safe space where all persons would receive care, non-judgement, and togetherness. A true people person, she had a wonderful way of connecting with colleagues, partners, and community members and building relationships wherever she went. Amy's farewell message is as follows:

> *I am deeply grateful to NORDIK Institute, its incredible staff, research associates, and leadership. I'm proud to have witnessed its growth and sustainability. It is an honour to have been part of an organization that continues to make such a meaningful impact across Northern Ontario.*

We are grateful for Amy's dedication and many contributions over the years. Most of all, we will miss her friendly presence and the positivity she brought to our team. Thank you, Amy, for being such an important part of NORDIK. We wish you all the very best in the next chapter in your professional journey!

Team Members

RESEARCH ASSOCIATES

Dr. Aaron Gordon (Algoma University)
Dr. Ahmed Aziz (Algoma University)
Dr. Ajmery Sultana (Algoma University)
Prof. Andrea Pinheiro (Algoma University)
David Thompson (Rural Agri-Innovation Network, Sault Ste Marie Innovation Centre)
Dr. Edward Turgeon (Algoma University)
Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone (Algoma University)
Elizabeth Garcia (Colombian Ambassador in Bolivia)
Dr. Gayle Broad (Algoma University)
Haley MacLeod (Wildlife Conservation Society of Canada and Trent University)
Dr. Jen Davies (Algoma University)
Dr. Joanne Azevedo (Algoma University)
Dr. Jody-Lynn Rebek (Algoma University)
Dr. Laura Wyper (Algoma University)
Dr. Linda Savory-Gordon (Algoma University)
Dr. Mahreen Nasir (Algoma University)
Dr. Melanie Goodchild (Algoma University)
Michael Burtch (Artist, Art Historian)
Dr. Michael Twiss (Algoma University)
Dr. Nusrate Aziz (Algoma University)
Dr. Sean Meades (Algoma University)
Dr. Sheila Gurner (Algoma University)
Dr. Susan Chiblow (University of Guelph)
Dr. Tamanna Rimi (Algoma University)
Dr. Teryn Bruni (Algoma University)
Dr. Ushnish Sengupta (Algoma University)
Dr. Vivian Jimenez-Estrada (Algoma University)
Dr. Zamilur Rahman (Algoma University)

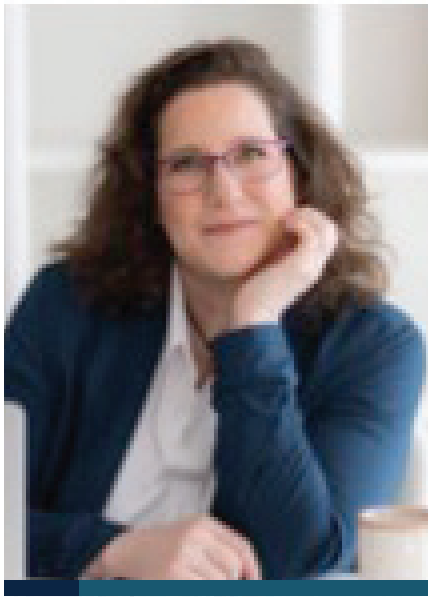
EMPLOYEES

Aidan Tibben
Ajaz Shaikh
Anne Arnott
Athul Narayanan
Carley Vinkle
Christopher Masha
Elizabeth MacMillan
Harsh Morye
Heather Fraser
Isaac Withers
James Akintipan
Josephine Ojerinde
Kiki Vetrie
Mandar Velapure
Mark Trudeau
MD Soaib Hossain
Meenu
Muhammad Hassan Jamil
Natalie Lesage
Prince Dey
Quazi Sakib
Rohil Patel
Shahzad Shahzada
Tara Burrell
Taylor Barker
Vivek Verma

STUDENTS (PLACEMENTS AND INTERNSHIPS)

Anurag Adhikari (AU's CESD Department)
Cheryl Toulouse (AU's CESD Department)
Navleen Khehra (AU's CESD Department)
16 Indigenous high school students from 10 Nations: Mohawks of the Bay of Quinte, ON; Hiawatha First Nation, ON; Mohawks of Akwesasne, ON; Curve Lake First Nation, ON; Beardy's and Okemasi's Cree Nation, SK; Lake Manitoba First Nation, MB; Kahnawake, QC; Nlaka'pamux Nation, BC; Shuswap Band, BC; and St'at'imc Nation, BC.

We Welcome Our New Research Associates



Dr. Joanne Azevedo

Assistant Professor in the Social Work Department, in the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences at Algoma University.

Research Interests: Systemic racism; embedded colonizing practices within social work and social services; systems and policies that perpetuate oppressive practices and colonizing structures.

Dr. Joanne Azevedo is based at Algoma University's Sault Ste. Marie campus. Dr. Azevedo holds a PhD in Social Work from York University in Toronto. Prior to seeking her PhD, she worked in child welfare for more than two decades. Dr. Azevedo has focused her scholarship on issues related to systemic racism and oppressive practices that remain embedded within child welfare services. Dr. Azevedo is an active member of the Child Welfare Truth Telling Collective, a group that seeks to contribute towards Truth and Reconciliation in various ways, including examination of ways that child welfare practitioners have and continue to engage in colonial practices, ways that systems of child welfare cause harms to families and communities, and imagining ways to challenge colonizing systems of child welfare. Dr. Azevedo has widened her scholarship to explore ways to guide future social workers towards practices that disrupt systems of white supremacy and systemic oppression in social work, and child welfare practices. Recent research work has shifted to include ways that social work scholarship can collaborate with environmental, land back and land defense movements.



Dr. Jen Davies

Assistant Professor in the Social Work Department, in the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences at Algoma University.

Research Interests: Systems change, especially around issues of diversity, equity, inclusion and belonging, challenges and success factors for recent immigrants in Canada, and skills development for helping professionals. During her Doctorate in Education in Counselling Psychology for Community and Educational Settings at the University of Toronto (OISE, 2019) her research focused on the career motivations of recent immigrants to Canada.

Dr. Jen Davies is based in Timmins, where she grew up. Jen's background is in counselling and psychotherapy, especially in career development and experiential learning in post-secondary settings. Previously she served as the Director, Co-op, Career and Experiential Learning at Georgian College, and for 8 years prior she served as Manager, Career Development Services at the University of Toronto Scarborough. It was there she developed knowledge of effective practices in diversity, equity, inclusion and belonging. Her team's equity-focused work won her the Emerging Leader Excellent Award at UTSC in 2020.

As a long-time volunteer leader in the Career Counsellors and Post-Secondary Counsellors chapters of the Canadian Counselling and Psychotherapy Association, Jen is familiar with a range of the challenges faced by counselling professionals across the country.





Dr. Mahreen Nasir

Assistant Professor, Faculty of Computer Science and Technology, Algoma University

Research Interests: Data Science, Data Mining, Big data Analytics, Artificial intelligence, GenAI, Recommendation Systems

Dr. Mahreen Nasir is a distinguished educator and researcher specializing in Data Mining, Artificial Intelligence, Deep Learning, and Generative AI with research spanning diverse applications including Recommendation Systems, Health care (Infectious Disease Prediction, Mental Health & Well Being), Anomaly Detection in Connected and Autonomous Vehicles, Social Media and Web Accessibility. With a Ph.D. in Computer Science from University of Windsor, her work delves into complex data analysis to uncover actionable insights across these interdisciplinary fields. Dr. Nasir's teaching portfolio spans across South Asia, the Middle East, and North America, where she has significantly contributed to undergraduate and graduate Computer Science education by teaching several courses including Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning and Computer Networks. Dr. Nasir actively contributes towards supervision of undergraduate and graduate students' thesis and projects leveraging AI, Machine Learning and GenAI for recommendation systems and beyond, mentoring students for participation in global international AI competitions (Gold and Bronze Medal Winners). Dr. Nasir has been awarded various research grants, including AURF, Strategic Initiative RCM funding, Teaching and learning innovative fellowships and several competitive Mitacs research awards. Her scholarly contributions include several publications and serving the academic community as a reviewer in esteemed ACM and IEEE journals and conferences.



Dr. Ajmery Sultana

Assistant Professor in the Department of Computer Science and Mathematics at Algoma University

Research Interests: Dr. Ajmery Sultana is a dedicated researcher and educator whose work bridges the gap between cutting-edge technology and community-centric solutions. She brings a wealth of expertise in next-generation networks, quantum computing, artificial intelligence, and blockchain technology. Her research is driven by a commitment to developing secure, intelligent, and sustainable systems that address real-world challenges.

At the core of Dr. Sultana's work is a passion for applied research that yields tangible benefits for society. She actively explores how quantum-resistant frameworks can safeguard our digital infrastructure, how machine learning can enhance predictive analytics in sectors from healthcare to agriculture, and how decentralized technologies like blockchain can create more transparent and equitable energy marketplaces. Her projects, including a privacy-aware student wellness monitoring system and the early detection of disease in livestock using computer vision, demonstrate a profound dedication to leveraging technology for social good and community well-being.

This commitment to community extends deeply into her professional service. A passionate advocate for equity, diversity, and inclusion in STEM, Dr. Sultana has served as a mentor and judge for ElleHacks, Canada's largest hackathon for women and gender-diverse students. She actively fosters the next generation of technology leaders through her leadership roles within the IEEE Toronto Section, including as Chair of the Vehicular Technology Society Chapter and Vice-Chair of the Communication Society Chapter. By organizing seminars, workshops, and international conferences, she builds dynamic bridges between academia, industry, and the broader community.

Executive Summary

By the Numbers

40+ Community Collaborations

22 Total Projects

GOAL 1

Advance partnership for Indigenous research sovereignty.

8 Projects

GOAL 2

Foster local and regional dialogues on issues critical to Northern Ontario and Indigenous communities.

19 Projects

GOAL 3

Cultivate research talent with a supportive, inclusive, team-based atmosphere.

18 Projects

GOAL 4

Connect students, researchers and community in projects that contribute to social, economic and environmental sustainability and social justice for Northern and Indigenous communities.

17 Projects

6 Projects initiated or co-led by an Indigenous organization or person

8 Projects involving community-based researchers.

5 Projects involving Indigenous community-based researchers.

- **26 NORDIK EMPLOYEES**
  Full-time and part-time.
- **3 INDIGENOUS HIRES**
- **19 STUDENT PLACEMENT POSITIONS (of which 17 were indigenous)**
  In high school, college, and university.

2025-2026 NORDIK Institute Projects

SECTION TITLE	PROJECT LEAD(S)	LEAD EMAIL(S)	PAGE
Anji inaashkawun - Waves of Change	Dr. Jody Rebek Dr. Ahmed Aziz	jody.rebek@algomau.ca ahmed.aziz@algomau.ca	15
Beyond Financial Incentives: Lessons on Rural Physician Recruitment	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Ahmed Aziz	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca ahmed.aziz@algomau.ca	16
Community Reclamation, Revitalization, Regeneration & Resilience	Dr. Laura Wyper	laura.wyper@algomau.ca	16
Community Support Team: Ongoing support for Children of Shingwauk Alumni Association	Tara Burrell	Tara.Burrell@algomau.ca	17
Community Support Team: The Unmarked Burial Project	Tara Burrell	Tara.Burrell@algomau.ca	19
Counting Every Voice: Building Better Evidence for Northern Communities	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Ahmed Aziz	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca ahmed.aziz@algomau.ca	20
Cultural and Creative Industries: A Pro-Active, Future-Focused Approach to Community Resilience	Dr. Jude Ortiz	jude.ortiz@algomau.ca	21
Data North Dashboard: Illuminating Paths for Progress in Northern Ontario	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Zamilur Rahman Dr. Ahmed Aziz Dr. Teryn Bruni	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca zamilur.rahman@algomau.ca ahmed.aziz@algomau.ca teryn.bruni@algomau.ca	22
From Evidence to Everyday Support: Rethinking ADHD in the Workplace	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Ajmery Sultana	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca ajmery.sultana@algomau.ca	23
From News to Financial Stress: A High-Frequency Canadian Index Assessment Tool	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Zamilur Rahman Dr. Ahmed Aziz	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca zamilur.rahman@algomau.ca ahmed.aziz@algomau.ca	24
Global Decolonial Education Initiative with Strengthening Networks for Alternative Education Structures	Dr. Sheila Gruner	sheila.gruner@algomau.ca	25
GLOCAL: Global Mindsets for Local Regenerative Futures	Dr. Jody-Lynn Rebek	jody.rebek@algomau.ca	26

2025-2026 NORDIK Institute Projects (*cont'd*)

SECTION TITLE	PROJECT LEAD(S)	LEAD EMAIL(S)	PAGE
Intercultural, Experiential, Decolonizing Learning and the Faculty of Cross-Cultural Studies	Dr. Sheila Gruner Dr. Vivian Jimenez-Estrada	sheila.gruner@algomau.ca vivian.jimenez-estrada@algomau.ca	27
Keepers of the Circle Entrepreneurship Program	Amy Boyer Elizabeth MacMillan	elizabeth.macmillan@algomau.ca	27
Leveraging Newcomers' Skill Sets to Tackle Labour Shortages in Northern Ontario	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Ahmed Aziz Dr. Zamilur Rahman	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca ahmed.aziz@algomau.ca zamilur.rahman@algomau.ca	28
Mask-wa Oo-ta-ban: Cree for Bear Train	Dr. Linda Savory-Gordon	linda.savory-gordon@algomau.ca	29
Measuring What Matters: Strengthening the Valuing Ontario Libraries Toolkit (VOLT)	Dr. Tamanna Rimi Dr. Sean Meades Dr. Jude Ortiz	tamanna.rimi@algomau.ca sean.meades@algomau.ca jude.ortiz@algomau.ca	29
Toward a Provincial Organization for Community Engaged Artists	Dr. Jude Ortiz	jude.ortiz@algomau.ca	30
Transdisciplinary Leader Development for Sustainability	Dr. Laura Wyper Dr. Jody-Lynn Rebek	laura.wyper@algomau.ca jody.rebek@algomau.ca	30
Water Team: Empowering communities to steward local waters	Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone	elaine.ho-tassone@algomau.ca	31
Water Team: The next four years	Corrina Barrett Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone	cbarrett@ssmrca.ca elaine.ho-tassone@algomau.ca	32
Weather Stations and Spruce Budworm Moth Detection	Dr. Jennie Pearce Dr. Jean-Noel Candau	jlpearce@shaw.ca jean-noel.candau@nrcan-rncan.gc.ca	33

Research and Development





Anji inaashkawun

WAVES OF CHANGE

Over the last year, as part of the Freshwater and Blue Economy project, our team has launched the **Anji Inaashkawun website** that hosts a database of freshwater actors around the Great Lakes, as well as local water resources, educational materials, and historical events. An Indigenous Advisory Circle was formed to guide the future directions of this action research project. Our collaboration with Junior Water Walkers and the Algoma District School Board has led to the development of educational resources for school students in honour of World Water Day.

Team members presented project findings at various conferences, including the International Association for Great Lakes Research (IAGLR) and the Canadian Water Resources Association (CWRA). We also published an article, “The Place of the Rapids: Community Perspectives on Freshwater Health, Challenges, and Opportunities,” in the Journal of Great Lakes Research.

We also piloted two Subjective Atlas mapping workshops to explore the deep human connections that sustain freshwater health and how freshwater creates life. One workshop was hosted by the NORDIK Water Rangers team. The other was hosted by Algoma University Visual Art Studio and local artist Annie King. Art and stories were integrated into the Subjective Atlas Map by weaving local art and personal stories directly into our research mapping, we build a richer picture of our waters.

Alejandra Pascagasa secured grants at the University of Manitoba, and we also received Responsibility Centred Management (RCM) funding for this project.

Research team: Research Associates Dr. Jody-Lynn Rebek and Dr. Ahmed Aziz; Algoma University staff Kamran Abbasov and Amber McKay; María Alejandra Pascagasa-Usaquén (University of Manitoba), and Courtney Vaughan (Lakehead University).

Beyond Financial Incentives

LESSONS ON RURAL PHYSICIAN RECRUITMENT

Access to primary healthcare is fundamental to healthy and resilient communities, yet many rural and Northern regions across Canada continue to face persistent shortages of family physicians. In Canada, rural and remote communities account for approximately 18% of the population but are served by about 8% of physicians, reflecting a longstanding structural imbalance in the health workforce. This project responds to a critical policy question for rural and Northern communities: can financial incentives meaningfully improve the distribution of family physicians?

The study examined Saskatchewan's Rural Physician Incentive Program, which was introduced in 2013 and offered direct annual payments to recent medical graduates establishing family practice in rural communities. Using administrative physician data from the Canadian Institute for Health Information and population data from Statistics Canada, the team analyzed data from 2009 to 2021 to assess whether the program improved the distribution of physicians between rural and urban areas.

The findings offer an important lesson for health workforce planning in Northern Ontario. Rural physician rates remained persistently below urban rates, and the analysis found no statistically robust evidence that the incentive program narrowed the rural–urban physician supply gap. Rather than dismissing incentives altogether, the study suggests that stand-alone financial payments may be insufficient when deeper structural barriers such as, professional isolation, family employment opportunities, infrastructure, and rural practice support, remain unresolved.

These findings provide practical evidence for governments, health organizations, and rural communities seeking more effective approaches to strengthening the healthcare workforce. They reinforce the need for integrated recruitment and retention strategies that address both economic and social factors influencing physicians' decisions about where to practice. A project output of the study was to inform others through an article in Social Science & Medicine Journal.

Research team: NORDIK staff Dr. Tamanna Rimi and Quazi Nazmus Sakib; Research Associate Dr. Ahmed Aziz.

Publication: Sakib, Q. N., Aziz, A., & Rimi, T. (2026). Do Financial Incentives Affect Rural Physician Supply? Empirical Evidence from a Canadian Experiment. Social Science & Medicine. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2026.119578

Community Reclamation, Revitalization, Regeneration & Resilience

This project started in the spring of 2023 with on site research conducted in Italy with municipal leaders with the hope to identify strategies for rural regeneration that are transferable from rural Italy to rural Ontario contexts. The project continues with literature reviews and further research in the Ontario context.

Research Team: Research Associate Dr. Laura Wyper.

Community Support Team

ONGOING SUPPORT FOR CHILDREN OF SHINGWAUK ALUMNI ASSOCIATION

Mino Bimaadiziwin, funded by the Ontario Ministry of Indigenous Affairs and First Nations Economic Reconciliation, is focused on the health and well-being of Survivors of Indian Residential School, as well as their families and those who work with them. We aim to develop a network of health authorities, Knowledge Keepers, and Elders who have successfully provided Indigenous-led and culturally centered programs to support those impacted by the Shingwauk Indian Residential School on their journey to recovery from mental health and addictions. This network includes those who work on and off reserve, within and outside of Northern Ontario, in support of impacted families from more than 85 First Nation communities.

A series of events was held to foster relationships, make space for healing, and build skills for moving forward from mental health and addictions challenges in a healthy way. For example, the Community Support Team assisted the CSAA to host its annual gathering in August 2025, themed Life after Residential School. The event took place at multiple locations and was host to approximately 400 attendees. On September 9 and 10, 2025, NORDIK Institute hosted a two-day Trauma Training session for our Community Support Team, led by Dr. Kathy Absolon. This event took place at NORDIK Institute's downtown office. Shortly after, on September 16, 2025, CSAA and the Community Support Team hosted a Kairos Blanket Exercise with Phil Jones,



Survivors and their families at the entrance of the former Shingwauk Indian Residential School (present-day Algoma University), during the Life After Residential School gathering in August 2025.



Community Support Team members participating in Trauma Training with Dr. Kathy Absolon.



Kairos Blanket Exercise attendees at the Water Tower Inn.

Knowledge Keeper from Garden River First Nation. The Kairos Blanket Exercise is a symbolic truth-telling experience in which non-Indigenous persons learn about colonization through the experiences of Indigenous persons. This event took place at the Water Tower Inn and included representation community organizations across Ontario.

As we plan this project's completion by spring 2027, the final phase is to develop a Data Management Dashboard. This Dashboard is intended to be an open-access data management initiative that will support the abilities of Indigenous communities & organizations and non-Indigenous organizations & service providers to access a variety of Residential School-related information collected through our partners and five years of our team's research. Our team built relationships with individuals and organizations to gather local information (Algoma region) as well as collect publicly available information from 71 communities.



Screenshot of the landing page for the Data Management Dashboard.

At the closing of this initiative in 2027, we will host a public launch in appreciation of those that attended and contributed to previous events like our Wellness Summit in 2024, and to thank those community warriors who work tirelessly to provide services, programs and workshops that address the impacts of Indian Residential Schools. The launch is also intended to showcase and demonstrate the achievements of Survivors and their families through publicly accessible documents and resources available through the Dashboard. Outreach activities for the public launch are currently underway, and we look forward to reporting on this initiative in the 2026-2027 Annual Report!

Project Team: NORDIK staff Tara Burrell, Anne Arnott, Ajaz Shaikh, Chris Masha, Muhammad Hassan Jamil and Aidan Tibben; contributing members of the CSAA, including George Diamond, Margaret Diamond, Shirley Horn, Jackie Fletcher, Marjorie Lee, John Saylors, Daisy Kostus, Harvey and Delores Trudeau, Paula Edwards, and Nellie Mitchell.

Community Support Team

UNMARKED BURIALS

The Community Support Team is a partnership between the Children of Shingwauk Alumni Association (CSAA) and NORDIK Institute. The CSAA have marked many achievements, despite uncertainty for those leading searches for Indigenous children that did not return home from Residential Schools across Canada.

TBD

The Unmarked Burials project is focused on giving voice to the Survivors of Indian Residential Schools, sharing their truths, and undertaking a grounds-search at the former Shingwauk Indian Residential School (present-day Algoma University, where NORDIK is headquartered) for unmarked graves. At NORDIK Institute, Indigenous methodologies continue to guide technological solutions that address the history of colonialism and the continued impacts of residential schools in Canada. Indigenous-led, community centered approaches to research align with and adhere to OCAP® principles and the United Nations Declaration of Rights of Indigenous Peoples, ensuring improved processes that are more reliable, transparent, accountable, and usable.
As part of the truth-telling component of this project, NORDIK's Community Support Team has partnered with the Office of the Chief Coroner of Ontario's Residential School Death Investigation Team (RSDIT) to make Residential School records more accessible to the Survivors, their families, and the public. Since 2021, RSDIT conducted a series of investigations, combing through thousands of archived records, related to deaths at Indian Residential Schools in Ontario. Their investigations produced large amounts of data that are currently stored in a massive (~70,000 data entries) spreadsheet. This spreadsheet is difficult to navigate, may be misplaced/altered and/or deleted, and creates copies after data updates that may appear as duplicate spreadsheets. To address these concerns, NORDIK's staff with specialized programming and data stewardship expertise are developing a user-friendly, cost-effective, cloud-based solution - the Shingwauk Database - that requires little administrative capacity to implement. The Shingwauk Database is being co-developed with the CSAA and RSDIT.

Project Team: NORDIK staff Tara Burrell, Anne Arnott, Heather Fraser, Ajaz Shaikh, Chris Masha, Athul Narayanan, Mandar Velapure, Eyad Gad, MD Soaib Hossain, James Akintipan, and Aidan Tibben; contributing members of the CSAA, including George Diamond, Margaret Diamond, Shirley Horn, Jackie Fletcher, Marjorie Lee, John Saylors, Daisy Kostus, Harvey and Delores Trudeau, Paula Edwards, and Nellie Mitchell.

Counting Every Voice

BUILDING BETTER EVIDENCE FOR NORTHERN COMMUNITIES

For many rural and Northern communities, online surveys have become one of the few practical ways to engage immigrants and collect local evidence. They are easier and cheaper to distribute than many traditional surveying methods (e.g. mailed questionnaires, in-person interviews) and are able to reach people across large geographic areas. For municipalities and immigrant-serving organizations, voluntary online surveys can be a practical option when no clear sampling frame exists. However, an important question remains: do these online surveys truly reflect the experiences of the communities they aim to serve? This project examines whether the convenience of online surveys comes with a methodological cost: do online surveys capture the broader immigrant population, or mainly those who are easier to reach and more likely to respond?

The study reviewed survey reports prepared by municipalities and Local Immigration Partnerships across Canada. It used several indicators and statistical tests to assess whether the survey samples reflected the populations they aimed to study. Census statistics were treated as the reference point, and survey responses were compared with census patterns for key immigrant characteristics, including admission category and country of origin. The study also compared achieved sample sizes with random-sampling benchmarks to assess whether the samples were large enough to support reliable interpretation. Importantly, the analysis went beyond documenting non-representativeness. It also explored the factors that may drive it.

The findings show that voluntary online surveys often do not represent immigrant populations accurately. Many surveys did not meet sample size benchmarks, and several lost responses because of incomplete submissions, ineligible participants, or bot-generated entries. The surveys also tended to underrepresent economic and family class immigrants while overrepresenting refugees. Additional correlation and Qualitative Competitive Analysis (QCA) revealed that non-representativeness is not only caused by survey design, outreach strategy, or implementation choices, but also by the demographic structure of the community being surveyed. When the target population makes up a larger share of the municipal population, it appears harder for voluntary online surveys to produce representative samples.

The project helps municipalities, Local Immigration Partnerships, and community organizations better understand the strengths and limitations of voluntary online surveys, supporting more informed decisions about newcomer settlement, workforce development, and community planning. As Northern communities continue to welcome newcomers, better evidence will be essential to ensuring that local policies and services reflect the experiences of the people they are intended to serve. The study's findings are captured in the manuscript, *Can Voluntary Online Surveys Deliver Representative Data? Evidence from Immigrant Survey Practices in Canada*, examining this issue using Canadian immigrant surveys as the empirical case.

Research team: NORDIK staff Dr. Tamanna Rimi and Quazi Nazmus Sakib; Research Associate Dr. Ahmed Aziz.

Cultural and Creative Industries

A PRO-ACTIVE, FUTURE-FOCUSED APPROACH TO COMMUNITY RESILIENCE

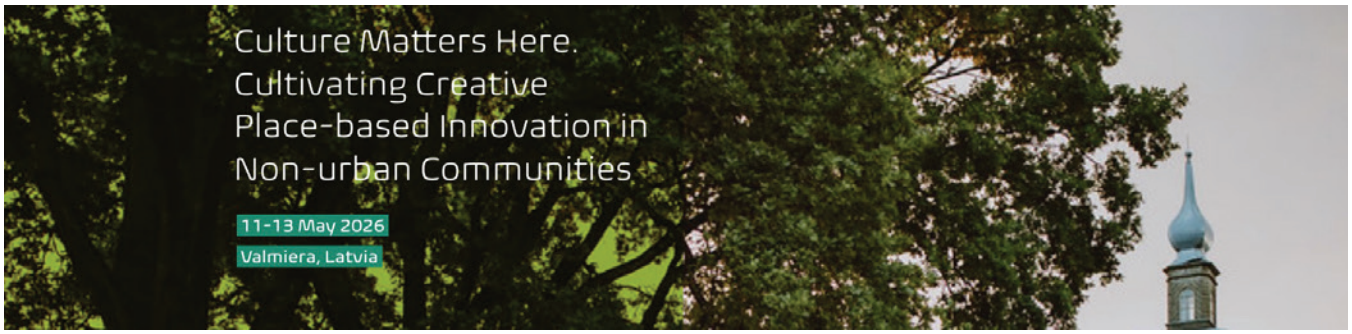
The IN SITU research focusing on innovation in cultural and creative industries in rural areas in the European Union concluded in May 2026 with a conference in Valmiera, Latvia. As a member of the project's International Advisory Board, Dr. Jude Ortiz presented at the event providing a comparison between her research conducted in Northern Ontario and insights gleaned through the 4-year capacity-building and investigative initiative. There are many similarities between the two regions.

The 12 EU site locations utilized participatory action research in bringing together artists and university researchers to build on its unique cultural and natural history within its geopolitical context. As with culture-led place-based development in Northern Ontario, European artists are gaining momentum and expertise in fostering diverse relationships within their local communities, and across distances, contributing to creating healthy, resilient people and locales. The positive impact of culture development is evident—engagement in creative activities supports individual and collective identity and belonging, continuous learning, entertainment and enjoyment, and tourism, economic diversification and regeneration.

diversity of people for a variety of socioeconomic reasons, its propensity for social and human capital development, and significant knowledge and network spillovers that benefit productivity in other sectors, it is positioned as a powerful resource for building equitable and inclusive regeneration that supports opportunities for all to participate and flourish. Rural locales are now increasingly recognized as sites of innovation, creativity and hubs of cultural production, challenging the traditional urban bias. It repositions the arts, culture and heritage—transcending the boundaries of being amenities to improve the quality of life—to becoming the foundational premise and resource upon which to build vibrant, resilient people and places. The research calls for investment in social, organizational and built infrastructure in generating creative solutions for a pro-active future-focused approach to community futures.

The IN SITU project brought together 13 institutional partners in 12 countries. It was also accompanied by an array of Outreach Partners within Europe and internationally. In addition, the project had an International Advisory Board of seven leading international experts working on CCIs and culture-based work in non-urban areas. It was coordinated by the Centre for Social Studies at the University of Coimbra, Portugal, and was funded by the European Commission under the Horizon Europe programme.

Research team: NORDIK Institute staff Dr. Jude Ortiz; and Dr. Nancy Duxbury (University of Coimbra).



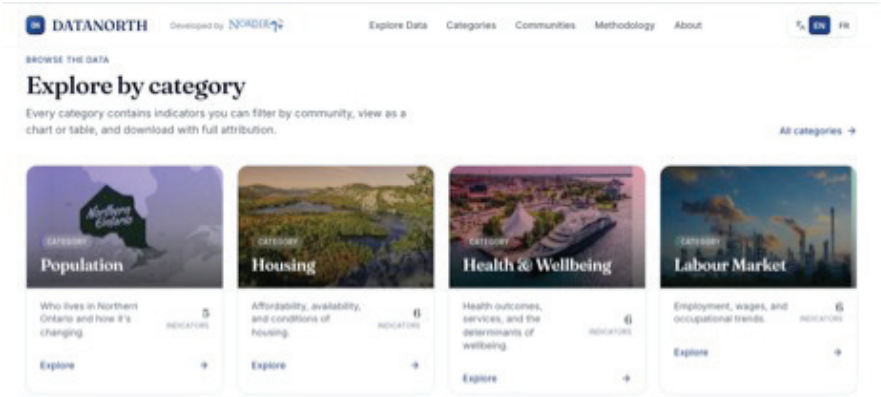
IN SITU's final conference.

Data North Dashboard

ILLUMINATING PATHS FOR PROGRESS IN NORTHERN ONTARIO

Northern Ontario's rural and smaller communities need reliable, locally relevant information to understand changing needs, plan services, advocate for resources, and make informed decisions. Yet community-level data can be difficult to find, fragmented across multiple sources, or unavailable for smaller communities. Data North, led by NORDIK Institute and DeScide Lab, Algoma University, is working to change that by creating an accessible platform for understanding Northern Ontario through data. By bringing fragmented information together in one place, Data North aims to strengthen evidence-based planning, research, program development, advocacy, and community decision-making across Northern Ontario.

Building on the community engagement and consultations undertaken during Phase 1, this year's work focused on transforming the Data North vision into a functional resource. The project developed a working prototype of the Data North website, establishing the foundation for a user-friendly data hub that makes community information easier to access, visualize, and interpret.



Data North Platform

The platform is currently being populated with an expanding collection of indicators across demographic, economic, health, housing, education, and other socio-economic areas. Alongside publicly available secondary data, Data North is being designed to incorporate primary, community-generated data, helping create a richer and more locally relevant picture of Northern communities in the future. An important part of this year's work has also been building the foundation for Data North to become a trusted and sustainable resource. Considerations around data quality, privacy, accessibility, governance, and responsible data sharing are informing the platform's ongoing development. With the working platform taking shape, the research team is preparing for the Phase 2 launch of Data North, marking an important step toward making Northern community data more visible and useful.

Looking ahead, Data North will continue to expand its indicators and data sources through consultations with community partners and organizations to share their shareable data and design the platform to meet their needs while strengthening the governance framework needed to support a trusted, evolving resource for Northern communities, researchers, service providers, and decision-makers.

Research team: NORDIK staff Dr. Tamanna Rimi (NORDIK Institute), MD Soaib Hossain; Research Associates Dr. Zamilur Rahman, Dr. Ahmed Aziz, and Dr. Teryn Bruni; Dr. Muhammad Azam (Algoma University), and Nitin Bhatti (Algoma University student).

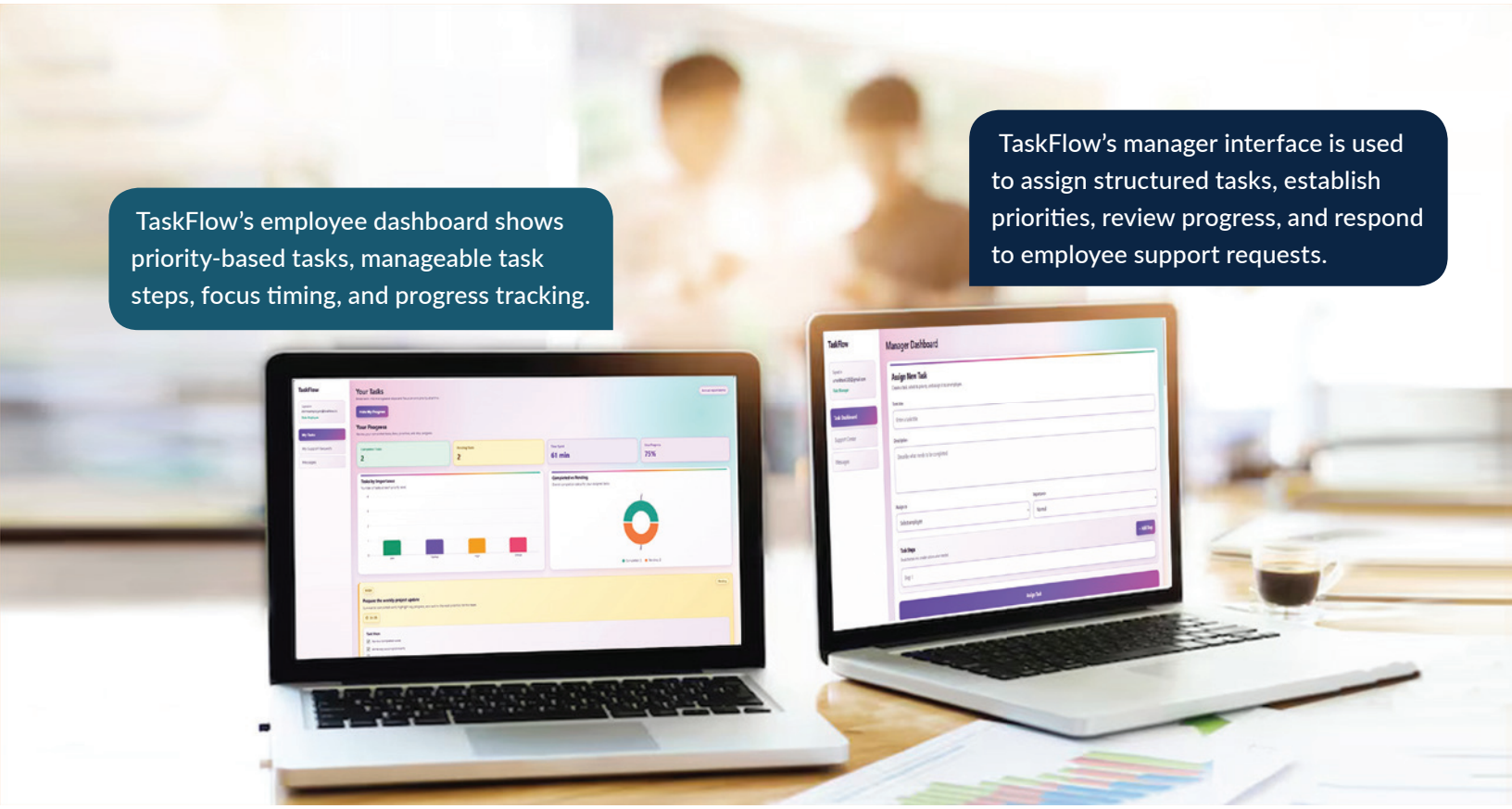
From Evidence to Everyday Support

RETHINKING ADHD IN THE WORKPLACE

Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) is often understood through symptoms, but its effects reach much further into education, employment, family life, health service use, and economic participation. This project began by asking a broader question. 'How has the global research community understood the economic burden of ADHD, and where are the gaps that still limit policy and practice?' The research team examined this question through a bibliometric and thematic review of the literature.

The study found that research on ADHD's economic burden has grown rapidly, particularly after 2015, but remains geographically concentrated and thematically uneven. The review showed that the literature is still centered largely on pediatric ADHD, productivity outcomes, and cost-of-illness estimation, while adult ADHD, caregiver burden, and life-course impacts remain less developed. These findings pointed the project toward a practical opportunity to support adults with ADHD in the workplace, where planning, prioritizing, managing mistakes, and regulating stress can directly affect confidence, productivity, and inclusion.

Building on this evidence, the team is developing a workplace-focused ADHD support app. The app is designed to help users break tasks into smaller steps, organize work by priority or recency, receive



ADHD Workplace Support App

supportive guidance when mistakes occur, and avoid panic through structured coping prompts. A panic button is being developed to connect users with expert or consultant advice when immediate support is needed. Other features include progress tracking, reminders, and a reward system to reinforce task completion. The prototype is currently being reviewed with employers who employ people with ADHD.

By translating research findings into practical supports, the project reflects NORDIK's commitment to community-engaged innovation and applied research that improves inclusion, workforce participation, and quality of life. As the prototype evolves, it has the potential to support employers in creating more inclusive workplaces while empowering adults with ADHD to thrive in their careers.

Research team: NORDIK staff Dr. Tamanna Rimi, Quazi Nazmus Sakib, and Mushfika Binta Latif; Research Associates Dr. Ajmery Sultana and Dr. Ahmed Aziz; and Umer Khan (Algoma University student).

Publication: Sakib, Q. N., Rimi, T., Latif, M. B., & Aziz, A. (2026). Economic burden of attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder: A bibliometric and thematic analysis. Journal of Public Health. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10389-026-02835-8

From News to Financial Stress

A HIGH-FREQUENCY CANADIAN INDEX ASSESSMENT TOOL

Financial stress and economic uncertainty can affect communities through multiple channels, including access to credit, business investment, employment, household confidence, and local economic activity. However, Canada's traditional measures of financial and economic stress rely on market-based indicators, surveys that are low-frequency and often miss rapid changes in sentiment and perceived risk as they emerge. To the best of the research team's knowledge, no real-time mechanism for tracking financial stress currently exists in the Canadian context.

Earlier identification of emerging financial and economic stress can help policymakers, financial institutions, researchers, and community economic development organizations better understand changing economic conditions and anticipate potential impacts on businesses, workers, households, and communities. For community development, this type of timely information can provide an early signal of broader economic pressures that may eventually affect employment, business activity, investment, and demand for community and social supports. An accessible, regularly updated index could therefore complement existing economic indicators and support more timely, evidence-informed planning and decision-making.

This project addresses that limitation by constructing a high-frequency Financial Stress Index (FSI) for Canada from publicly available posts on X (formerly Twitter) by five major Canadian news outlets spanning January 2017 to

September 2025. Using a multi-stage pipeline, the project identifies finance-related posts and combines multiple financial sentiment models into a single daily composite grounded in contemporaneous news sentiment. The resulting FSI co-moves with established monthly benchmarks while remaining a distinct narrative signal, carries short-horizon predictive content for the Canadian Economic Policy Uncertainty Index, and strengthens its association with the S&P/TSX 60 Volatility Index during periods of heightened financial stress.

The first phase of the project, which involved developing the FSI and conducting its initial validation, has been completed. The second phase has also been completed and included extensive robustness checks, a comprehensive validation of the index, preparation of the research paper, and presentation of the findings at the Canadian Economics Association Conference.

The third and final phase is currently ongoing and focuses on developing an interactive website that will provide regularly updated FSI values, so the results are more accessible to researchers and the public. This stage also includes submitting the research paper for publication in a peer-reviewed journal.

Research Team: NORDIK staff Dr. Tamanna Rimi and Md Soaib Hossain; Research Associates Dr. Zamilur Rahman and Dr. Ahmed Aziz; and Eyad Gad (Algoma University intern).

Global Decolonial Education Initiative

STRENGTHENING NETWORKS FOR ALTERNATIVE EDUCATION STRUCTURES

The Global Decolonial Education Initiative (GDEI) creates spaces for dialogue, educational programming, and collaborative activities to advance decolonization and self-determination in education. In its fourth year, the initiative hosted several international delegations at Algoma University, including a delegation of Indigenous and Afro-Colombian leaders in May 2025, former Colombian Minister of Equality and Equity Carlos Rosero in October 2025, and Afro-Colombian musician and activist Victor Hugo Rodriguez in February 2026. The initiative also organized a delegation of Anishinaabe Chiefs and members of the Robinson Huron Waawwindamaagewin (RHW) to Colombia in June 2025, to strengthen partnerships and explore opportunities for collaborations between the IPTP and communities in Northern Ontario.

These exchanges have strengthened the established relationships between Algoma University and partners around the globe, advancing a shared vision for alternative educational models grounded in Indigenous knowledge systems, intercultural dialogue, and collaboration. New institutional agreements were formalized with universities in Ghana, Colombia and Costa Rica, as well as with local governments and grassroots organizations in Colombia.

Additionally, through the IPTP, the GDEI also supported the establishment of the International Environmental Alliance for the Protection of Life and Biodiversity, a process which started in early 2025 and was formalized through a joint declaration in October 2025, in preparation for COP 30 in Brazil.

The Alianza is formed by grassroots organizations, community councils, local governments, social leaders and activists from around the world to advance collective action for environmental protection and the defence of life.

Research Team: Research Associate Dr. Sheila Gruner; Fernanda Arenas Suxo (Algoma University), Cheryl Toulouse (Algoma University student), Kristen Jones (Algoma University student), and an international network of faculty, researchers, and community partners across Canada, Colombia, Bolivia, Ghana, Senegal and South Africa.

Filler photo

GLOCAL

GLOBAL MINDSETS FOR LOCAL REGENERATIVE FUTURES

In 2026 BRIDGE Lab students and assistants engaged in preliminary work to develop the INPLASY protocol for the scoping review that now informs the design of a leader development intervention. A manuscript based on this work is scheduled for summer submission to Planetary Health. To amplify this work, the BRIDGE Lab redesigned its website to include a dedicated blog, creating a platform to highlight our laboratory's research, attract community-based collaborations, and establish our scholarly work as a catalyst for regenerative leadership actions.

Our lab has attracted national momentum, which continues to increase attendance at the upcoming November 2026 Canadian Scholars Retreat, which will host dedicated and deeply invested researchers and practitioners from across the country. Applying a Tri-Sector Community Innovation Strategy, this initiative unites public, private, and social sectors to co-design research for the long-term well-being of northern communities through business education and regenerative approaches.

By mobilizing key resources, expertise, and infrastructure, the BRIDGE Lab is creating actionable processes for change in the Sault region. In the coming months, we anticipate numerous opportunities for knowledge dissemination, including peer-reviewed publications, conferences, practical applications and solutions in businesses, and artistic exhibits. A NORDIK NOHFC intern is supporting the project.

Research team: Research Associate Dr. Jody Rebek; NORDIK staff Taylor Barker.

Intercultural, Experiential, Decolonizing Learning and the Faculty of Cross-Cultural Studies

In the second year of the project, The Intercultural, Experiential, Decolonizing Learning offered numerous collaborative and experiential learning opportunities to Algoma University students, including a condensed Community Economic and Social Development (CESD) course in October 2025, "Environmental policy justice, governance and historical reparations," and an interdisciplinary CESD, Sociology and Music condensed course in February 2026, "Music, Territory, and Social Movements." Both courses featured scholars, community leaders, and partners from Colombia and Canada, providing students with opportunities to engage with diverse perspectives and lived experiences. The project also made significant progress toward the development of a new graduate program at Algoma University, including the establishment of an international advisory body with scholars and educators from Canada, Colombia, Ghana, and the United Kingdom.

In summer 2025, the project collaborated with the IPTP to facilitate an international placement experience for Algoma University biology student Émilie Vezina. During her two-month placement in Bogotá, she visited and learned alongside Indigenous and Afro-Colombian communities and organizations.
The project is also collaborating with the IPTP in an Autonomous Economies initiative, which seeks to establish alternative trade networks between the Global North and the Global South, to advance the self-determination, economic sovereignty and autonomy of local communities. As part of this initiative, the project has contributed to the development of pedagogical material and a curriculum focused on economic justice through the lens of peoples' diplomacy.

Research team: Research Associates Dr. Sheila Gruner and Dr. Vivian Jimenez-Estrada; Fernanda Arenas Suxo (Algoma University); and the Institute of Peoples, Territories, and Pedagogies for Peace.

Keepers of the Circle Entrepreneurship Program

The ongoing partnership between NORDIK and Keepers of the Circle (Temiskaming Native Women's Support Group) that began in 2023, continues to co-create a more inclusive Canadian economy through social enterprise development. Introduction and intermediate entrepreneurship programming focuses on ideation and business plan development while connecting Indigenous female and two-spirit entrepreneurs across the country with the knowledge they seek, and with other people from different First Nations, Inuit, and Metis communities. We show up and learn differently than in mainstream entrepreneurship programs, with purposeful engagement through caring and intentional conversations. We support the entrepreneurship journey through nurturing confidence and self-care practices.

Project Team: NORDIK staff Amy Boyer and Elizabeth MacMillan; Odessa Turner (Keepers of the Circle), and Darlene Skani (Keepers of the Circle).

Leveraging Newcomers' Skill Sets to Tackle Labour Shortages in Northern Ontario

Many employers across Northern Ontario continue to face persistent labour shortages, while newcomers often struggle to find employment that matches their education, skills, and professional experience. Bridging this gap requires more than being aware of and filling vacancies; it requires a better understanding of local workforce needs and the talents newcomers bring to the region. This project responds by building a clearer local evidence base for workforce planning in the Sault Ste. Marie and surrounding rural communities. The work brings together newcomer skill assessment, employer and service provider interviews, and existing local labour market data. The goal is not only to document labour shortages. It is to understand where newcomer skills, employer demand, training opportunities, and employment barriers intersect. The project also asks what supports newcomers need to align their education, experiences and long-term career goals to meet employer demands so newcomers can move into jobs.

A key part of this work was the development of the Sault Newcomer Skills Survey 2026, designed to capture information on newcomers' education, employment history, current employment status, intended occupations, job search experiences, barriers, and self-rated skill levels. We are currently co-developing the survey with community partners to ensure it reflects local priorities and the lived experiences of newcomers. Survey findings will be combined with employer perspectives, service provider insights, local job posting data, and existing secondary labour market information to create a more complete picture of workforce supply and demand. The project will also support the development of an AI-integrated labour market dashboard and skill-matching platform. The matching process will be place-based and grounded in Canadian labour market classifications. The platform is also being designed with employers in mind. Through an employer portal, businesses will be supported to identify the skills they are actually looking for, rather than relying only on broad job titles or generic requirements.

The project is funded by the Government of Ontario through the Rural Ontario Development Program (ROD) and DeScide Lab, Algoma University and is being developed through partnerships with the DeScide Lab, City of Sault Ste. Marie, Algoma Workforce Investment Corporation, Sault Community Career Centre, Northland Adult Learning Centre, Sault College Employment Solution, Superior Adult Learning, and Community Builders.

Research team: NORDIK staff Dr. Tamanna Rimi, Quazi Nazmus Sakib and Nazmul Hossen; Research Associates Dr. Ahmed Aziz and Dr. Zamilur Rahman.



Partner Engagement Session held in May 2026

Mask-wa Oo-ta-ban

CREE FOR BEAR TRAIN

The Mask-wa Transportation Association Inc. (MTA Inc.) and the coalition for Algoma Passenger Trains (CAPT) are addressing the lack of passenger train service in Northern Ontario. No passenger train service means that people are forced to use the most polluting modes of transportation—by road or air. The existing rail beds were built as colonial projects with the land taken from First Nations without consent and are now being used only for freight. The Bear Train will be a project of Reconciliation and an effort to mitigate climate change.

MTA, set up by Missanabie Cree First Nation, has been approaching the Federal and Ontario Governments to fund the Bear Train north of Sault Ste Marie. It will be the only Indigenous led passenger train in Ontario. CAPT has been providing advocacy support for the Bear Train by having official Federal and Ontario Government petitions signed. In September the petitions will be presented to the Canadian House of Commons by MP Terry Sheehan and to the Ontario Legislature by MPP Bill Rosenberg. Both organizations have board members from a broad diversity of populations in Northern Ontario, particularly from Indigenous communities. They also maintain strong partnerships with Missanabie Cree First Nation, Destination Northern Ontario, Algoma Country, the Municipalities of Wawa, Dubreuilville and Sault Ste. Marie, Thrive Tours Inc.

Project team: Research Associate Dr. Linda Savory-Gordon.

Measuring What Matters

STRENGTHENING THE VALUING ONTARIO LIBRARIES TOOLKIT

Building on the successful launch and adoption of the Valuing Ontario Libraries Toolkit (VOLT), NORDIK Institute continued its partnership with the Ontario Library Service (OLS) to strengthen the toolkit and ensure it remains relevant and reliable for public libraries across Ontario.

During this reporting year, the project focused on updating the VOLT toolkit based on user feedback and reviewing the data and values used to calculate libraries' Social Return on Investment. These regular updates help ensure that libraries have access to current and credible information when measuring and communicating their social and economic value to their communities and stakeholders.

The team also began developing a province-wide public survey to strengthen selected data used within the toolkit. The survey is designed to better understand which library materials and services Ontario residents could not or would not access elsewhere. The findings will help establish a province-wide baseline and provide stronger evidence for demonstrating the unique contribution public libraries make to their communities. Together, these activities represent the next stage in VOLT's development—moving beyond the initial creation of the toolkit toward its ongoing improvement, validation, and long-term use as an evidence-based resource for Ontario's public libraries. Visit https://resources.olservice.ca/volt for more information.

Research team: Dr. Tamanna Rimi, Dr. Jude Ortiz, and Harsh Morye; Research Associate Dr. Sean Meades; and Ontario Library team members Melissa D'Onofrio-Jones, Jesse Roberts, and Allison Pilon.

Toward a Provincial Organization for Community Engaged Artists

Community-engaged artists and organizations are one step closer to having a provincial organization dedicated to supporting their professional development and capacity. Such an organization would strengthen their ability to assist communities to build social capital, nurture resiliency, share stories, revitalize cultural traditions, promote active citizenship and tackle big ideas or challenges. Community-Engaged Arts (CEA) is an inclusive practice and unique creative form whereby professional artists collaborate with community members to co-create new artistic works.

The research to identify a model for the provincial organization was led by Thinking Rock Community Arts in partnership with NORDIK Institute and funded by the Ontario Arts Council's Strategic Collaborations Fund and the City of Sault Ste. Marie's Arts and Culture Assistance Program. The report, *In Service of our Stories: Co-Designing a Community-Engaged Arts Service Organization*, is available on the Thinking Rock Community Arts and NORDIK Institute websites. The next steps in the process of establishing a dedicated organization are to identify funding and investment opportunities, and to develop an operational plan.

Research team: NORDIK staff Dr. Jude Ortiz and Elizabeth MacMillan; Miranda Bouchard (Thinking Rock Community Arts).

Transdisciplinary Leader Development for Sustainability

This project explores the decolonization of education from the perspective of settler academics using a two-eyed seeing approach with community-based pedagogy (CBP). After participating in a condensed week-long course in Spring 2025, delivered by the settler academics, students were surveyed and interviewed. Findings from the course and participants' research responses are intended to inform the development of similar future programming. At this stage, the research findings indicate positive outcomes from the current programme, with an emphasis on maintaining 50% Indigenous content delivered by community knowledge holders in future interactions of the course.

Research Team: Research Associates Dr. Laura Wyper and Dr. Jody Rebek.

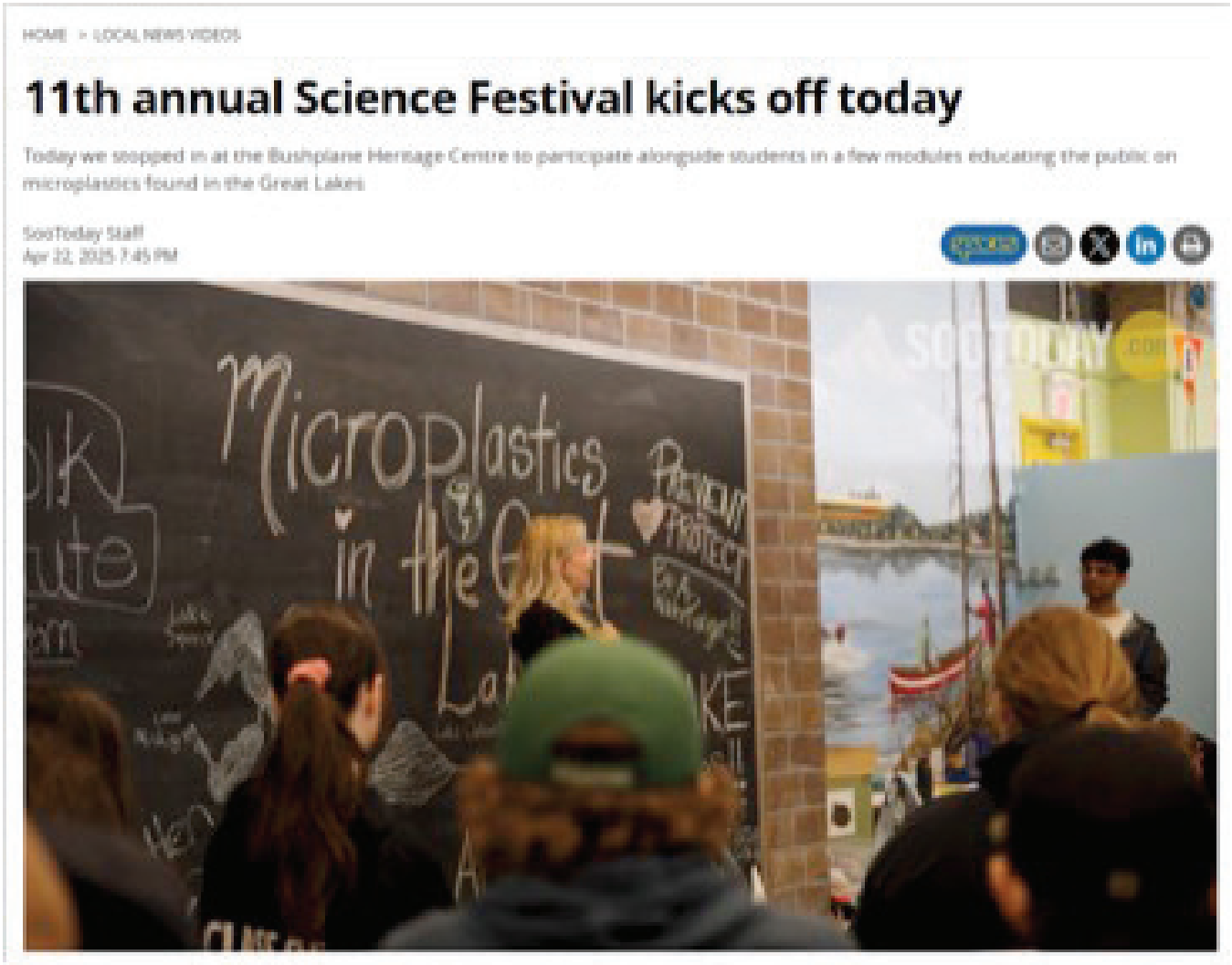
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Water Team

EMPOWERING COMMUNITIES TO STEWARD LOCAL WATERS

A new logo for the SOURCE Water (Shaping Outreach, Understanding Research, & Community Engagement with Water) Team at NORDIK Institute

The Community-based monitoring in the northern Great Lakes project was implemented in the Algoma District - a region of the Lake Superior and Lake Huron watersheds with increasing water stress and limited capacity to track potential impacts of water-related decisions. There is sparse availability of data, with a lot of extrapolation from the small urban regions to represent the vast rural areas. Our project was a two-year initiative that builds on a collective six years (2020-2026) of community partnerships



HOME > LOCAL NEWS VIDEOS

11th annual Science Festival kicks off today

Today we stopped in at the Bushplane Heritage Centre to participate alongside students in a few modules educating the public on microplastics found in the Great Lakes

SooToday Staff
Apr 22, 2025 7:45 PM

Soo Today feature showing a recording of our team as the main event at the kick-off of the week-long 2025 Science Festival. NORDIK's Water Team members engaged with about 80 youth to raise awareness about microplastics and water quality.

for Northern Ontario waterways. The objectives of this project were to: (1) Engage community members to collect water chemistry, lab samples, and record observations; (2) Develop and evaluate a practical approach to community-based science for the Northern Great Lakes communities by developing a framework for data collection and use; and (3) Consider what (data) equity looks like between Indigenous and non-Indigenous communities in Northern Ontario. The project was primarily funded by the Ontario Ministry of Environment, Conservation and Parks, the Canada Water Agency, and the Northern Ontario Heritage Fund, though there were many others who provided cash and in-kind contributions.

The capacity this project has contributed to Northern Ontario is immense. Our accumulated (six-year) efforts resulted in 46 locations in the Upper Great Lakes basin now being monitored by nearly 200 volunteers, collecting more than 40,000 freely accessible data records (in addition to lab sampling, eDNA, qualitative observations, physical characteristics, and data collected with the use of computerized sensors). Our collaborations resulted in the creation of 17 paid positions, >30 internships (about half were Indigenous students), the bringing together of more than 30 collaborators, engaging more than 10,000 people across the Algoma region, and attracting more than $1 million in cash and in-kind support to our waters! In the 2025-2026 fiscal year, we also undertook a comprehensive road salts study and a microplastics campaign in Sault Ste. Marie.

Project team: NORDIK staff Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone, Kiki Vetrie, Ajaz Shaikh, Carley Vinkle, Isaac Withers, Rohil Patel, and many incredible community co-leads, volunteers, and partners.

Water Team

THE NEXT FOUR YEARS



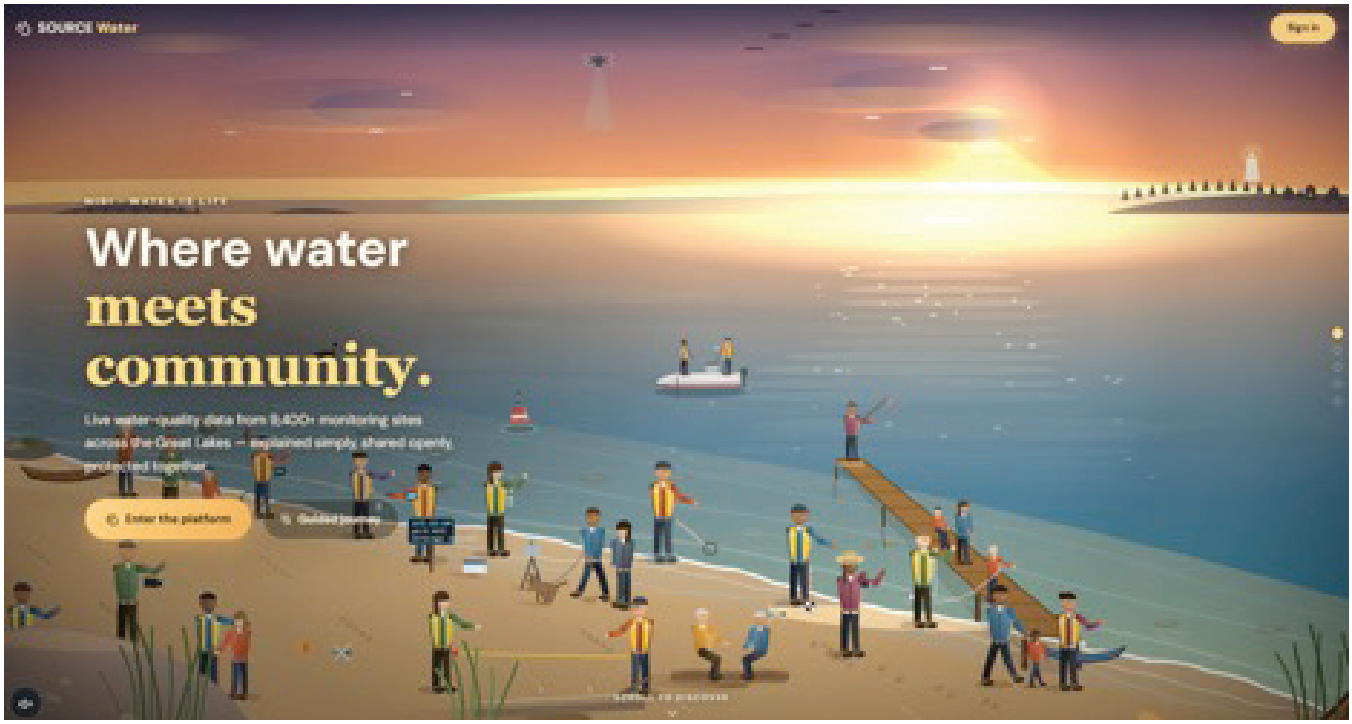
A living droplet gives water a voice on NORDIK's new Waterdata Engagement Platform.

Building on the two-year initiative led by NORDIK from 2024-2026, this next phase is led by the Sault Ste. Marie Region Conservation Authority, in collaboration with NORDIK. The project is primarily funded by the Canada Water Agency and the Northern Ontario Heritage Fund, though there are many others who are providing cash and in-kind contributions.The current phase began in 2025 and runs until spring 2029, with objectives to expand community monitoring initiatives, develop a cold-climate community monitoring toolkit, and to create pathways for decision-makers to utilize the growing amount of community-curated data.

In addition, this next phase includes a pilot Water Conversations series, in which we explore ways to adapt or supplement existing Provincial government water data systems to be more conducive to Indigenous ways of knowing and doing. Finally, the first phase project (described above) resulted in a new initiative born this year: an online, AI-powered engagement platform that enables community

members to shift from simply accessing data to understanding, interacting with, learning about, and applying the data together with other community members. The current name for this initiative is the Waterdata Engagement Platform (waterdata.ca).

Project team: NORDIK staff Dr. Elaine Ho-Tassone, Kiki Vetrie, Ajaz Shaikh, Carley Vinkle, Isaac Withers, Rohil Patel; Corrina Barrett (Sault Ste. Marie Region Conservation Authority); and many incredible community co-leads, volunteers, and partners.



Screenshot of the landing page for the Waterdata Engagement Platform.

Weather Stations and Spruce Budworm Moth Detection

Spruce Budworm is a native moth species whose preferred host plants are balsam fir and spruce. During periods of high population levels, defoliation leads to considerable mortality of its host species over large areas, leading to significant impacts on timber supply. Spruce Budworm spread through long-distance dispersal flights that establish new epicenters of defoliation. These mass flights can be seen on weather radar.

In collaboration with Environment Canada, the research team has developed a tool to monitor Spruce Budworm mass dispersal flights, as captured by Environment Canada's weather radar network. Using this tool, we have mapped the historical (2013-2025) movements by Spruce Budworm. This has improved understanding of the frequency, duration and distance travelled during these flights. This information will improve predictive models being developed by project partners, and will assist in the early detection of new Spruce Budworm outbreaks. Natural Resources Canada funded this project from 2023-2026. While the project is now complete, a new phase to automate the predictive models using artificial intelligence and machine learning has commenced for the 2026-2027 fiscal year.

Research team: Dr. Jennie Pearce (Pearce & Associates Ecological Research) and Dr. Jean-Noel Candau (Canadian Forestry Service, Natural Resources Canada).

THANK YOU TO OUR FUNDERS AND PARTNERS!

NORDIK Institute is proud to collaborate with more than 40 organizations in the 2025-2026 fiscal year. Most of these organizations are represented here; however, this list is not exhaustive and we thank all others who may not be represented here. Thank you for working with us!



Northern Ontario Research, Development, Ideas and Knowledge

NORDIK INSTITUTE

Research, Dialogue, Analysis and Reflection

Northern Ontario Research, Development, Ideas and Knowledge Institute

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